

Ceiling coffers or panels diminish in size as they rise, adding to the sense of height.

The **oculus** (“eye”) is open to the elements—rainwater drains away through the floor.

Rings of concrete made with lightweight pumice stone become narrower toward the top.

The **pediment** is set above Corinthian columns to form a Classical entrance.

Bronze household god

The Romans worshipped a variety of ancestral gods (*lares* and *penates*) as guardians of their homes. This bronze statuette holds a drinking horn, a typical attribute of a household god.

of Augustus (the city’s principal public meeting place); Trajan’s Column, completed in 113 CE, with reliefs celebrating two victories over the Dacians; and Constantine’s Arch, finished in 315 CE, to mark the military might of Emperor Constantine I. The triumphal arch is a form that the Roman Empire made its own, and it has been copied up to the present day.

Life in the Roman Empire

Everyday life continued in many ways as it had done during the republic. Male citizens had varying freedoms, while women were mainly confined to the domestic arena. Slaves, with no

The Pantheon

Created as a temple in the 2nd century CE, the Pantheon in Rome is famed for its dome, the largest until modern times. Over 70 ft (21 m) high, with a diameter of over 140 ft (43 m), cement mixed with pumice near the top of the dome helps support the structure.

HOW WE KNOW

POMPEII

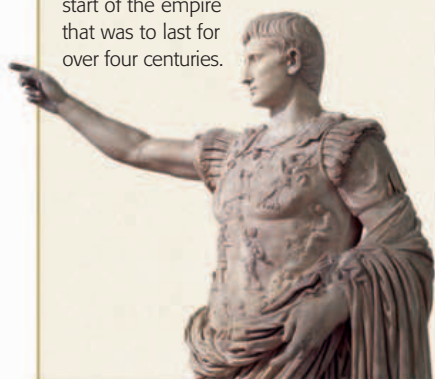
In August 79 CE, a massive eruption of Mount Vesuvius buried the nearby Roman city of Campania (now called Pompeii) in southern Italy under 20 ft (6 m) of ash and debris. Buildings were buried and people smothered. Neighboring cities, such as Herculaneum, were similarly affected. Excavation has revealed a perfectly preserved example of a sophisticated Greco-Roman city of around 20,000 people, with buildings such as a forum, amphitheater, and lavish villas. Even the remains of loaves in bakers’ ovens were preserved. Many human bodies left their shapes in the ash, from which plaster casts have since been made (below), showing Pompeii’s people as they fell.



ROMAN EMPEROR (63 BCE–14 CE)

EMPEROR AUGUSTUS

Augustus was the Roman Empire’s first emperor. He was born Octavian, and was Julius Caesar’s grand-nephew and adopted son. After Caesar’s death he assumed the title Augustus, a name that had religious implications, and Princeps, meaning “first citizen.” He brought an end to civil war, and appeared to be restoring the republic to its glory days, but in reality ruled as an autocrat. He held power for 41 years of relative peace, heralding the start of the empire that was to last for over four centuries.



» vast array of human and natural resources, and a diverse web of trading connections. Its provinces traded all kinds of basic and luxury goods with each other, ranging from salt to mass-produced statues—which is why ancient Rome is often called the “warehouse of the world.”

Throughout its many provincial cities and towns, the empire brought into being some of the really great works of ancient Roman architecture, engineering, and art. Imperial-era buildings and monuments took the Romans’ love of impressive grandeur to a peak, proclaiming their wealth and power to the world.

Augustus oversaw the transformation of Rome, saying he “found [it] a city of bricks and left it a city of marble.” Many magnificent

structures were built. This was made possible due to expertise in arch construction (see p.108) and the discovery of cement (limestone and clay) to make concrete.

The concrete revolution

The Romans had already made great inroads with the use of concrete (see pp.106), and by the time of the empire were using it very skillfully on a large scale. The immense load-bearing capacities of concrete, along with further advances in the application of architectural elements like the arch, meant that they could produce massive structures such as Rome’s Colosseum, the enormous dome of the Pantheon (above), long aqueducts and viaducts (bridges), and harbors such as Caesarea

Maritima in Judea in the Middle East. Other monumental imperial structures include three famous sights in Rome—the Forum

50,000 The number of spectators that could fit into the Colosseum in Rome. It was built between c.72 and 82 CE to stage a variety of “entertainments,” including battle reconstructions, gladiatorial combat, dramas, and executions.